

# Business Reporting 101



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**Why is business reporting so important?  
(Even if business isn't your beat?)**



## TIP #1

Private companies can seem like they are impenetrable until the moment they are not. Look for an inroad from multiple angles.

- LinkedIn, Facebook, Instagram, Twitter
- Zoominfo
- Court records, attorneys
- News clips
- 911 calls
- LexisNexus Public Search

# How else to find new sources

Who is being quoted  
in existing coverage?

Find the people who  
will be impacted.

Go beyond the  
spokesperson, always.

Read the boring reports.  
Who are the authors and  
study experts?

Don't just ask to speak to the  
CEO. Ask for interviews with  
their C-suite, too.

Find local professors to  
break it down for you.

## TIP #2

Craft an outreach message that you're comfortable with company management reading. Even if you're reaching out via personal email, **assume that executives will read it eventually.**

Hello,

I hope this email finds you well. I'm Alexa Gagosz and I'm a business reporter for the Boston Globe.

I'm working on a story about the state of health care in Rhode Island and am looking to speak to former and current employees of [REDACTED] to hear about their experiences.

Do you have time for a 10-minute call? My number is [REDACTED] if you want to send me a text to set it up. Or would you like to meet for coffee sometime this week? Until then, I'll look forward to hearing from you.

Best,

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**Alexa Gagosz**

Reporter, [Rhode Island](#)

The Boston Globe



## **TIP #3**

Unfortunately, you cannot FOIA companies. But think about the touchpoints about where the company might interact with the government – whether it's local, state, or federal agencies.

# Easy - but critical - records to get

- **Government contracts**
  - If there are contracts, find the original bids on public projects. Did the company live up to the terms of the contract? Was the company actually the lowest and best bid?
- **State and federal grants?**
  - Then audits are likely required. Check the Federal Audit Clearinghouse federal grants, including state-pass through programs.
- **Emails** with city officials and departments, depending on what you're looking for.
- **Do they owe back taxes?**
  - Reach out to municipal financial directors or tax assessors and ask. Every town is different and they're usually pretty good about getting you that information quickly.
- **Calls for service list** for the company's addresses/ 911 responses made to business
- **Inspection reports**
  - For hospitals, nursing homes, other health centers, etc.
  - Restaurants, school and university cafeterias, etc.
- OSHA's establishment search
- **Building permits**
- **Deeds, property records**
- **WARN notices** with local labor departments
  - Ask for the actual letter the company sent.
- **FTC complaints**
- **Consumer complaints**
- **Business corporate filings.** Start with your state's Secretary of State's office.
- **Congressional Committee Meetings.**

## Tip 4: Internal records

**Use the phrase:** "Is there anything you can show me related to this matter or issue?"

- Get copies of emails, financial statements, announcements to employees, newsletters from the CEO, etc.
- BUT: Do not have them create documents for you.

Get **annual reports** or **impact reports** from the company.

- These are usually flashy and studded with PR word salad. But look at the footnotes. This is sometimes how you can find donors, financial information, etc.



## Tip 5: Earnings Calls + Transcripts

For public companies, there are regular earnings calls and transcripts that can be easily found on their website (look for investor pages). Mark them on your calendar, register to attend them, and they contain great audio from executives and analysts. This works great if you're in radio and TV, but also you can find out if a public company is making a big move through these calls.

- **For example:** CVS will announce they are divesting from one of their subsidiaries on these calls, they might discuss a change in leadership – even the CEO – or even say they are closing hundreds of stores – like they did a few years ago through these calls. You don't have to wait for someone like Bloomberg or CNBC to report it first. You can break the news.

## Tip 5: Earnings Calls + Transcripts (cont.)

- If IT has access to Bloomberg Terminal, use it.
  - **Pro tip:** Boston Public Library has access to this. Go to the basement and use it.
- Look through the EDGAR search on the SEC's website for Securities Filings.
- Bond reports and meetings.
  - Some hospital and health care systems will literally send you a link to the Zoom meeting. I usually have no trouble.

## Tip 6: Use Google Search more effectively

If you're a reporter and not using Advanced Google Search, you're not using Google to your advantage.

- Filter by site type (like .gov or .org)
- Filter by file type (such as a PDF, etc)
- Be specific when searching for someone or a company name, and use quotes if there's multiple words.
  - Example: "Alexa Gagosz" instead of Alexa Gagosz
  - Try different formats of the same name: "Gagosz, Alexa" for citations, academic papers they've written for PhDs, Masters, or book bibliographies, etc.

**Also:**

- Set up Google Alerts for people and companies.
- Start every morning with a simple Google Search

## Tip 7: Check these other places for ideas

- FOIA reading rooms
- Use MuckRock
- Opencorporates website
- Public pension funds.
  - Request records detailing investment proposals, vetting and review by the pension board and records tracking performance of investments
- ICIJ has a great database of offshore companies. Some of those might be tied to private companies.

# How to drive coverage

Build a calendar.

Get in the habit of asking sources for scoops and exclusives.

Think about the holes in existing coverage. (What is being overlooked?)

Be more proactive in thinking about the news of the day.

Go to places others haven't or won't.

# Thank you!

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